

Prayer

A practical guide towards daily prayer

3 Lesson 1: Prayer – the need for a miracle

Question:

- What do you think is the most important purpose of prayer?
- How is Christian prayer different from other faiths?
- Do you believe in miracles?
- Listen to <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Yg2l46Ny1yk>

3.1 Models for Prayer

Prayer is a means of communicating with God, allowing us to connect with Him, express our adoration, and present our needs. In everyday communication, we follow certain conventions; for example, speaking with a country's president requires etiquette. However, as a child of the president, one would approach differently. Similarly, communication styles vary across cultures and personal interactions. In the same way, the experience of prayer is shaped by the relationship you have with God and the level of intimacy you share with Him as your Father. The deeper the relationship, the more natural and heartfelt the communication becomes. Just as a close bond with a parent fosters open and confident conversation, a strong connection with God allows for more personal, honest, and transformative prayer.

3.2 Prayer Model: ACTS

Since prayer is directed to God, however, it is helpful to have some guidance on how to approach Him. There are a few models that can help to get used to a more complete prayer life. Below we will expose the ACTS model and briefly talk about a few other models.

Christian prayer often includes one or more key elements: Adoration, Confession, Thanksgiving, and Supplication (ACTS). Reflecting on this structure before praying can help maintain focus and cultivate the right mindset.

Adoration

The act of admiring, respecting, and worshiping God for His virtues and wondrous works. We adore the triune God simply because He is who He is.

An example of adoration in prayer:

"Lord, You are holy and mighty, full of wisdom and grace. You are the Alpha and the Omega, the Creator of all things. Your love is unfailing, and Your mercy knows no end. I praise You for Your goodness and faithfulness, for You alone are worthy of all honor and glory."

Confession

Confession is admitting our wrongdoing and acknowledging that we have acted in ways that fall short of God's glory. It is a humble recognition of our sins and a sincere request for His forgiveness.

An example of confession in prayer:

"Heavenly Father, I come before You with a humble heart, acknowledging my sins. I have failed to love as You command, spoken words that hurt and neglected to seek You wholeheartedly. Forgive me, Lord, and cleanse me from all unrighteousness. Help me to turn away from sin and walk in Your ways."

Thanksgiving

Thanksgiving is expressing gratitude for all that we receive from God, beginning with the gift of new life in Christ. We thank Him for His sacrifice, the example he has given us by showing His love for us and the countless blessings he gives.

An example of thanksgiving in prayer:

"Thank You, Lord Jesus, for taking my place, for bearing my sin on the cross so that I may have eternal life. I am grateful for Your love, grace, and mercy. Thank You for the daily provisions, the strength to face challenges, and the countless blessings, seen and unseen, that You pour into my life. I praise You with a thankful heart."

Supplication

Supplication is bringing our needs before God, trusting in His provision and care. We not only present own concerns but also intercede for others like friends and even our enemies. We pray for wisdom and strength and the use of our talents for His glory.

An example of supplication in prayer:

"Heavenly Father, I come before You with my needs and the needs of those around me. Please guide me, provide for me, and strengthen me in my journey of faith. I lift up my family, my friends, and even those who oppose me—may they experience Your love and peace. Help me to use my gifts wisely, that I may serve You and bring glory to Your name. Lord, I trust in Your perfect will and timing. Amen."

3.3 PRAY Model

P – Praise: Begin with worship and acknowledging God's greatness.

R – Repent: Confess sins and seek God's forgiveness.

A – Ask: Bring personal and intercessory requests before God.

Y – Yield: Surrender to God's will and listen for His guidance.

"Lord, You are holy and worthy of all praise. I confess my sins and ask for Your forgiveness. Please provide for my needs and bless those around me. I surrender my plans to You, trusting in Your perfect will."

3.4 2. TRIP Model

T – Thanksgiving: Express gratitude for God's blessings.

R – Repentance: Confess and turn away from sin.

I – Intercession: Pray for others.

P – Petition: Present personal needs before God.

"Thank You, Lord, for Your constant presence. I repent of my selfishness and ask for Your mercy. I lift up my friends and family in need, and I ask for Your guidance in my own life."

3.5 CATS Model (Similar to ACTS but in a different order)

C – Confession: Admit sins and ask for forgiveness.

A – Adoration: Worship and praise God.

T – Thanksgiving: Express gratitude.

S – Supplication: Bring requests to God.

"Father, I confess my shortcomings and seek Your mercy. You are mighty and worthy of all praise! Thank You for Your countless blessings. I ask for wisdom, strength, and provision for my needs."

3.6 Five-Finger Prayer Model (Helpful for intercessory prayer)

Thumb: Pray for those closest to you (family, friends).

Index Finger: Pray for those who teach and guide (mentors, pastors, teachers).

Middle Finger: Pray for leaders (government, church, and workplace).

Ring Finger: Pray for the weak (sick, poor, struggling).

Pinky Finger: Pray for yourself (personal needs).

"Lord, I lift up my family and friends. I pray for my pastors and teachers. Guide our leaders in wisdom. Help those who are suffering. Lastly, I bring my own needs before You and ask for Your help."

3.7 Formats for Prayer

Beside the existence of the above models for prayer, there are prayers that follow a specific format - template. These prayers maintain a structured pattern and have a set wording, ensuring consistency in worship. `

An example is the Book of Common Prayer, written in 1549 to be used in the Church of England. It provides a comprehensive collection of prayers, liturgies, and services for daily worship, sacraments, and special occasions. Used across Anglican traditions, it shapes both personal and communal devotion. Its blend of Scripture, tradition, and theology makes it a foundational text for structured prayer, guiding believers in their spiritual practice.

We will now follow the morning prayer As laid out in the Book of Common Prayer:

DAILY MORNING PRAYER

The Officiant may begin Morning Prayer by reading an opening sentence of Scripture. One of the following, or a sentence from among those provided at the end of the Office (pages 27-29), is customary.

Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord
Jesus Christ.

PHILIPPIANS 1:2

or this

I was glad when they said unto me, "We will go into the house
of the LORD."

PSALM 122:1

or this

Let the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart
be always acceptable in your sight, O LORD, my rock and my
redeemer.

PSALM 19:14

CONFESSION OF SIN

The Officiant says to the People

Dearly beloved, the Scriptures teach us to acknowledge our
many sins and offenses, not concealing them from our heavenly
Father, but confessing them with humble and obedient hearts
that we may obtain forgiveness by his infinite goodness and

mercy. We ought at all times humbly to acknowledge our sins before Almighty God, but especially when we come together in his presence to give thanks for the great benefits we have received at his hands, to declare his most worthy praise, to hear his holy Word, and to ask, for ourselves and on behalf of others, those things which are necessary for our life and our salvation. Therefore, draw near with me to the throne of heavenly grace.

or this

Let us humbly confess our sins to Almighty God.

Silence is kept. All kneeling, the Officiant and People say

Almighty and most merciful Father,
we have erred and strayed from your ways like lost sheep.
We have followed too much the devices and desires
of our own hearts.
We have offended against your holy laws.
We have left undone those things which we ought to have done,
and we have done those things which we ought not
to have done;
and apart from your grace, there is no health in us.
O Lord, have mercy upon us.
Spare all those who confess their faults.
Restore all those who are penitent, according to your promises
declared to all people in Christ Jesus our Lord.
And grant, O most merciful Father, for his sake,
that we may now live a godly, righteous, and sober life,
to the glory of your holy Name. Amen.

The Priest alone stands and says

Almighty God, the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, desires not the death of sinners, but that they may turn from their

wickedness and live. He has empowered and commanded his ministers to pronounce to his people, being penitent, the absolution and remission of their sins. He pardons and absolves all who truly repent and genuinely believe his holy Gospel. For this reason, we beseech him to grant us true repentance and his Holy Spirit, that our present deeds may please him, the rest of our lives may be pure and holy, and that at the last we may come to his eternal joy; through Jesus Christ our Lord. **Amen.**

or this

The Almighty and merciful Lord grant you absolution and remission of all your sins, true repentance, amendment of life, and the grace and consolation of his Holy Spirit. **Amen.**

A Deacon or layperson remains kneeling and prays

Grant to your faithful people, merciful Lord, pardon and peace; that we may be cleansed from all our sins, and serve you with a quiet mind; through Jesus Christ our Lord. **Amen.**

INVITATORY

All stand.

Officiant O Lord, open our lips;

People And our mouth shall proclaim your praise.

Officiant O God, make speed to save us;

People O Lord, make haste to help us.

Officiant Glory be to the Father, and to the Son, and to the Holy Spirit;

People As it was in the beginning, is now, and ever shall be, world without end. **Amen.**

Officiant Praise the Lord.

People The Lord's Name be praised.

Then follows the Venite. Alternatively, the Jubilate may be used.

One of these antiphons, or one from the seasonal antiphons provided at the end of the Office (pages 29–30), may be sung or said before and after the Invitatory Psalm.

The earth is the Lord's for he made it: *

O come, let us adore him.

or this

Worship the Lord in the beauty of holiness: *

O come, let us adore him.

or this

The mercy of the Lord is everlasting: *

O come, let us adore him.

VENITE

O Come

O come, let us sing unto the LORD; *

let us heartily rejoice in the strength of our salvation.

Let us come before his presence with thanksgiving *

and show ourselves glad in him with psalms.

For the LORD is a great God *

and a great King above all gods.

In his hand are all the depths of the earth, *

and the heights of the hills are his also.

The sea is his, for he made it, *

and his hands prepared the dry land.

O come, let us worship and fall down, *

and kneel before the LORD our Maker.

For he is our God, *

and we are the people of his pasture,

and the sheep of his hand.

3.8 The Lords Prayer

Read Matthew 6:9-13/

The disciples asked Jesus to teach them how to pray, and He responded with this prayer. It serves both as a *model* and a *format* for prayer. Thank God—prayer can be learned!

“Our Father in heaven,
hallowed be your name,
¹⁰your kingdom come,
your will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
¹¹Give us today our daily bread.
¹²And forgive us our debts,
as we also have forgiven our debtors.
¹³And lead us not into temptation,^[a]
but deliver us from the evil one.^[b]”

*for yours is the kingdom
and the power
and the glory
forever. Amen.*

3.9 Reading and applying the text

Grab a pen and paper (or any tool you use to record your reflections), set aside at least 15 minutes, and follow this exercise while making notes:

1. Read the text multiple times – familiarize yourself with the wording and structure.
2. Read with awareness – observe the different headings and themes.
3. Read verse by verse – reflect on what each verse means and how it applies to your life.

During this exercise, you may find yourself praying (SPIRIT) rather than studying (HEAD) or reflecting (MIND). Don’t let the exercise hinder your prayer—after all, our goal in studying is to connect with God. If you feel led to pray, do so, and you can always return to your study later.

REFLECTION ON "GIVE US TODAY OUR DAILY BREAD"

"AT FIRST, THIS VERSE FELT ODD TO ME. I CAN BUY BREAD, SO WHY SHOULD I PRAY FOR IT? YES, I KNOW SOME PEOPLE LACK FOOD, BUT SHOULD I CARE? I'M NOT A POLITICIAN OR A LEADER. MY BIGGER CONCERN IS WHETHER I'LL FIND A JOB AFTER I GRADUATE—THAT'S WHAT REALLY MATTERS TO ME. AFTER ALL, MY JOB WILL PROVIDE MONEY, WHICH IN TURN PROVIDES MY DAILY BREAD. SO, SHOULD I BE PRAYING FOR A JOB INSTEAD? THE VERSE TELLS ME TO PRAY FOR MY DAILY BREAD. HOW DOES THAT WORK?" (END OF INITIAL REFLECTION: OKE, I AM CHALLENGED AND NEED AN ANSWER)

GOD IS ABLE TO PROVIDE EVERYTHING I NEED—BECAUSE HE IS GOD. A JOB, DAILY PROVISIONS, ANYTHING. YET, HE TEACHES ME TO PRAY FOR MY DAILY BREAD—JUST ENOUGH FOR TODAY. I ALSO REMEMBER THAT HE TELLS ME NOT TO WORRY ABOUT THE FUTURE. SO, I LEARN THAT I CAN BE CONTENT WITH WHAT I HAVE EACH DAY." (CONCLUSION IN COMBINING DIFFERENT TRUTHS OF THE BIBLE)

SO, I PRAY: 'GOD, YOU WANT ME TO ASK FOR MY DAILY BREAD, AND I THANK YOU FOR ALWAYS PROVIDING IT. I HAVE MORE THAN ENOUGH. YET, I STILL WORRY ABOUT MY FUTURE, ABOUT FINDING A JOB AFTER MY STUDIES. BUT TODAY, I AM REMINDED THAT I CAN TRUST YOU. JUST AS YOU PROVIDED BEFORE. SO I COME BEFORE YOU SAYING THAT I TRUST YOU TO PROVIDE FOR ME TODAY AND TOMORROW. HELP ME TO SEE WHERE I NEED TO TRUST YOU MORE. AMEN.' (PRAYER)"

Using this approach, you can take the prayer Jesus taught and make it personal, connecting directly with Him. Practice this for each part of the Lord's Prayer, and you'll find a deeper meaning in your relationship with God.

3.10 Detail Commentary

As you reflect on the text, you may have questions or feel unchallenged. Sometimes, Bible verses may not resonate with you. In such cases, using a commentary can be helpful. A commentary provides a framework for applying the text to your own life.

Below, you will find references to the text from Blue Letter Bible

(<https://www.blueletterbible.org/>), with additional insights where applicable.

Our Father in heaven: The right kind of prayer comes to God as a **Father in heaven**. It rightly recognizes whom we pray to, coming with a privileged title that demonstrates a

privileged relationship. It does bring God close to us as a Father whilst it also clearly points out God is not only near: He is in heaven.

- It was very unusual for the Jews of that day to call God “**Father**” because it was considered too intimate. “There is no evidence of anyone before Jesus using this term to address God.” It is true that God is the mighty sovereign of the universe who created, governs, and will judge all things — but He is also to us a **Father**. He is our **Father**, but He is our **Father in heaven**. When we say “**in heaven**,” we remember God’s holiness and glory.
- This is a prayer focused on *community*; Jesus said “**Our Father**” and not “My Father.” “The whole prayer is social. The singular pronoun is absent. Man enters the presence of the Father, and then prays as one of the great family.”

Hallowed be Your name. Your kingdom come. Your will be done on earth as it is in heaven: The right kind of prayer has a passion for God’s glory and agenda. His **name**, **kingdom** and **will** have the top priority.

- Three petitions with a descending scale are made: Name -> Kingdom -> Will.
- Everyone wants to guard their own name and reputation, but we must resist the tendency to protect and promote ourselves first and instead put God’s **name**, **kingdom** and **will** first.
- Jesus wanted us to pray with the desire that the **will** of God would **be done on earth as it is in heaven**. In heaven there is no disobedience and no obstacles to God’s will; on earth there is disobedience and at least apparent obstacles to His will. The citizens of Jesus’ kingdom will want to see His will done as freely **on earth as it is in heaven**.
- “He that taught us this prayer used it himself in the most unrestricted sense. When the bloody sweat stood on his face, and all the fear and trembling of a man in anguish were upon him, he did not dispute the decree of the Father, but bowed his head and cried. ‘Nevertheless, not as I will, but as thou wilt.’” (Spurgeon)
- A man can say, “**Your will be done**” in different ways and moods. He may say it with fatalism and resentment, “You will do your will, and there is nothing I can do about it anyway. Your will wins, but I don’t like it” or he may say it with a heart of perfect love and trust, “Do Your will, because I know it is the best. Change me where I don’t understand or accept Your will.”
- One might rightly wonder why God wants us to pray that *His* will would be done, as if He were not able to accomplish it Himself. God is more than able to do His will without our prayer or cooperation; yet He invites the participation of our

prayers, our heart, and our actions in seeing His **will be done on earth as it is in heaven**.

Give us this day our daily bread. And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors. And do not lead us into temptation, but deliver us from the evil one: The right kind of prayer will freely bring its own needs to God. This will include needs for daily provision, forgiveness, and strength in the face of temptation.

- Three petitions in ascending direction follow.
- When Jesus spoke of **bread**, He meant real bread, as in the sense of daily provisions. Early theologians allegorized this, because they couldn't imagine Jesus speaking about an everyday thing like bread in such a majestic prayer like this. So they thought bread referred to *communion*, the Lord's Supper. Some have thought it referred to Jesus Himself as the bread of life. Others have thought it speaks of the Word of God as our daily bread. Calvin rightly said of such interpretations which fail to see God's interest in everyday things, "This is exceedingly absurd." God *does* care about everyday things, and we should pray about them.
- "The prayer is for our needs, not our greed. It is for one day at a time, reflecting the precarious lifestyle of many first-century workers who were paid one day at a time and for whom a few days' illness could spell tragedy." (Carson)
- "Sin is represented here under the notion of a *debt*, and as our sins are *many*, they are called here *debts*. God made man that he might live to his glory, and gave him a law to walk by; and if, when he does any thing that tends not to glorify God, he contracts a debt with Divine Justice." (Clarke)
- **Temptation** literally means a *test*, not always a solicitation to do evil. God has promised to keep us from any testing that is greater than what we can handle ([1 Corinthians 10:13](#)). "God, while he does not 'tempt' men to do evil ([James 1:13](#)), does allow his children to pass through periods of testing. But disciples, aware of their weakness, should not desire such testing, and should pray to be spared exposure to such situations in which they are vulnerable." (France)
- "The man who prays 'Lead us not into temptation,' and then goes into it is a liar before God... 'Lead us not into temptation,' is shameful profanity when it comes from the lips of men who resort to places of amusement whose moral tone is bad." (Spurgeon)
- If we truly pray, **lead us not into temptation**, it will be lived out in several ways. It will mean: Never boast in your own strength, Never desire trials, Never go into temptation, Never lead others into temptation.

For Yours is the kingdom and the power and the glory forever: The right kind of prayer praises God and credits to Him the kingdom and the power and the glory.

- There is some dispute as to whether this doxology is in the original manuscript Matthew wrote or was added in later by a scribe. Most modern Biblical scholars believe this line was a later addition.
- “It is *variously* written in several MSS., and omitted by most of the fathers, both Greek and Latin. As the doxology is at least very ancient, and was in use among the Jews, as well as all the other petitions of this excellent prayer, it should not, in my opinion, be left out of the text, merely because some MSS. have omitted it, and it has been variously written in others.” (Clarke)

3.11 Groupwork

1. What model of prayer can be derived from analysing the Lord’s Prayer?
2. How can you use the format of the Lord prayer to do a personal prayer?
3. After our discussion on prayer, take five minutes to reflect. What thoughts, questions, or conclusions stand out to you? Feel free to share in small group.
4. How can the Lord’s Prayer serve as a practical guide to improve your communication with God?
5. Why do faith, belief, and trust in Jesus shape the experience of prayer?
6. What questions do you have about prayer? Write them down and share them with Bert.

3.12 Homework

- When you pray at home, try to use the PRAY, ACTS, TRIP model. Is that useful or rather difficult? Make notes in your journal.
- Do the reflection on the Lords Prayer as suggested above in the exercise.
- Reflect on the questions if you do:
 - Appreciate the power of prayer?
 - Even have the privilege of prayer?
 - Understand the principles of prayer?
 - Manifest the persistence of prayer?
 - Engage in the practice of prayer